

The technique of 'driving' around town looking for Wi-Fi hotspots is termed as 'war driving'.

Give an appropriate IP address and click on the subnet mask field once. This will fill the empty field with a subnet mask. Click 'OK' and exit the Control Panel.

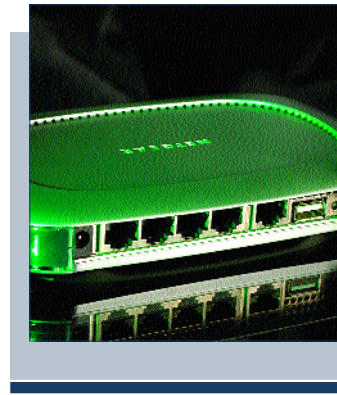


Check your IP information



Your network SSID

If all the settings are correct, you should be able to see the SSID—the one you typed in—highlighted in the utility after it scans for an available network.



When you see the SSID highlighted, your Wi-Fi card has successfully been set up as an Access Point! ■

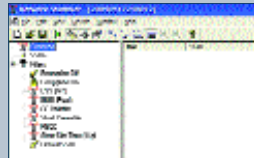
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▶▶ War Driving

NetStumbler is a neat tool made for the purpose of network scanning, and is a great addition to the arsenal of any network administrator worth his salt. This freeware utility is available for download from www.stumbler.net. It scans the surrounding area for available wireless connections within reach.

Note, however, that just by scanning, you cannot expect to log on and surf using that connection.

Using the utility is fairly simple. Install and run the utility, and click on the button on top that's shaped like a 'play' button. This will start the 'Scan' mode for NetStumbler, and it will start scanning and recording data.



NetStumbler's default view

The information provided is quite descriptive. It tells you about the signal strength, and whether or not any encryption (WEP) is used. The SSID, too, is displayed.

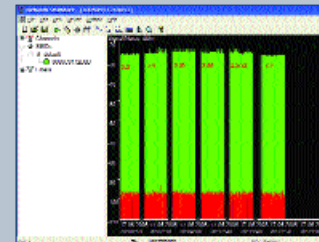
The display of the signal strength is particularly helpful for network administrators, as you can go around with a laptop and locate and mark dead spots or areas of poor signal strength.

In fact, the advent of pocket PCs prompted the author of NetStumbler to come out with a version that works with handheld PDAs that have Wi-Fi built in. This is called MiniStumbler, and can also be downloaded from www.stumbler.net.

Windows XP can natively display signal strengths, but the information is not as accurate as that provided by NetStumbler.

With NetStumbler, you also have the option of using GPS. If you have a Wi-Fi card with GPS capabilities, then you can run NetStumbler, enable GPS, and it will pinpoint the location of the Access Point!

The device requires absolutely no user input (apart from the click at the start!) and you can keep it running in the back seat of your car while you drive around the neighbourhood scouting for Wi-Fi hotspots.



The signal strength graph

SSID	BSSID	Channel	Signal Strength	Encryption
WIRELESS	WIRELESS	11	-50	WEP
WIRELESS	WIRELESS	11	-50	WEP
WIRELESS	WIRELESS	11	-50	WEP
WIRELESS	WIRELESS	11	-50	WEP
WIRELESS	WIRELESS	11	-50	WEP

Available active APs show up

The technique of 'driving' around the neighbourhood looking for Wi-Fi hotspots is termed as 'war driving'. Whether war driving is ethical is an ongoing debate: say you leave your house door open—intentionally or unintentionally; are you thus inviting people to take what they want from inside?

